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UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Memory and Active Recall: Remember More With Less Rereading

How memory actually works, and how to study in line with it

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Memory is not a recording device. This pack explains encoding, consolidation and retrieval, then converts that into concrete practice: retrieval questions, spaced schedules, flashcards done correctly and techniques for formulas and vocabulary.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain encoding, consolidation and retrieval in simple terms.
- Design retrieval questions instead of highlighting notes.
- Build and use a spaced-repetition schedule for a semester.
- Use mnemonics and elaboration without relying on them alone.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

How memory works

Information must be encoded, consolidated and retrievable. Each stage can fail.

- Encoding depends on attention and meaningful processing.
- Consolidation happens over time, especially with sleep.
- Retrieval strengthens memory more than rereading.
- Cues help retrieval; learning with varied contexts creates more cues.
- Forgetting is normal and can be countered with spaced review.
- Stress and sleep deprivation impair all three stages.

Retrieval in practice

Turn every page of notes into questions.

- Write questions on the left of the page and answers on the right.
- Close the notes and answer from memory before checking.
- Mark each attempt: confident, shaky or failed.
- Review failed items the next day, shaky items in three days.
- Mix old and new questions in one session.
- Use past questions as retrieval practice, not just as prediction.

> **The flashcard rules**
> One fact per card, a question on the front and a short answer on the back. If a card takes more than ten seconds to understand, split it.

Spacing, sleep and mnemonics

Timing matters as much as technique.

- Review after one day, three days, one week, two weeks and one month.
- Short frequent sessions beat one long session.
- Sleep after study supports consolidation; all-nighters trade memory for anxiety.
- Mnemonics help with lists but do not replace understanding.
- Elaboration - asking why and how - creates stronger, more flexible memories.
- Explain a topic aloud; gaps become obvious immediately.

How memory actually works

Memory is not a store that fills up; it is a set of processes. Information enters working memory, which is small and brief, and moves to long-term memory only through encoding. Retrieval is the act of bringing it back, and retrieval strength is what examinations measure.

Forgetting is not a malfunction. Without forgetting, you would be unable to distinguish what matters now. The forgetting curve is steep in the first day and flattens afterwards, which is why a review within twenty-four hours is disproportionately valuable.

Two principles follow. Spacing: distribute study across days so each session begins with partial forgetting that must be overcome. Retrieval: test yourself rather than review, because the effort of recall is what strengthens the memory.

Techniques that work and techniques that feel like work

Effective: closed-book recall, past questions, flashcards used correctly (guess before flipping), explaining a concept aloud to an imaginary listener, drawing a diagram from memory, and interleaving different problem types.

Ineffective despite feeling productive: rereading, highlighting, copying notes, summarising a chapter you have just read, and watching a video at normal speed without pausing to recall. These produce familiarity, which is easily mistaken for knowledge.

Elaboration strengthens memory by connecting new material to what you already know: ask how the concept relates to something you have seen, what it would explain, and what would contradict it. A concept connected to six others is easier to retrieve than one stored alone.

> **Guess before you check**
> A flashcard you flip without attempting recall is a reading exercise. The attempt, even a failed one, is what makes the next attempt easier.

Building a recall routine

Use a simple spaced schedule: review after one day, three days, one week, two weeks, one month. Adjust by difficulty. Keep the material small - five to ten items per session - and stop when recall becomes easy, because further repetitions at that point add little.

Write questions rather than statements. "What are the four stages of the nursing process?" is a recall prompt; "the nursing process has four stages" is not. Convert your notes into questions as you review, and you will have a question bank for the rest of the semester.

Test under the conditions you will be assessed in. Closed book, time limit, no phone. The closer practice is to the real conditions, the more useful the feedback.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Converting notes into recall prompts

You have one page of notes on inflammation.

1. Read the page once.
2. Close it and write every question the page could answer.
3. Aim for eight to twelve questions.
4. Answer them from memory the next day.
5. Mark the ones you could not answer and rewrite them in your own words.
6. Return to those specific items after three days.

> **What to carry forward**
> Questions are reusable; notes are not. Build the question bank once and use it all semester.

2. Making a study session efficient

You have forty minutes before a test.

1. Do not reread the chapter.
2. Take the topic list and mark each item: confident, shaky, unknown.
3. Spend twenty-five minutes on shaky and unknown items only, testing each.
4. Spend ten minutes writing a blank-page summary of the whole topic.
5. Check the summary and note what was missing.
6. Stop five minutes before the test and do nothing.

> **What to carry forward**
> Spend time where recall fails, not where it already succeeds.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the forgetting curve and its practical implication for study.

10 marks

1. Describe rapid initial forgetting that slows over time.
2. Explain that review shortly after learning intercepts the steepest loss.
3. State the practical implication: review within a day, then space.

Q2. Distinguish active recall from recognition and explain why it matters for examinations.

15 marks

1. Recognition is identifying material when present; recall is producing it.
2. Rereading trains recognition only.
3. Examinations require production under time pressure.
4. Describe techniques that train recall.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Working memory. The small, brief store used for current mental operations.

Encoding. The process of forming a memory trace.

Retrieval. Accessing stored information.

Forgetting curve. The pattern of rapid then slowing memory loss over time.

Spacing effect. Better retention when study is distributed over time.

Testing effect. Improved retention produced by retrieval attempts.

Elaboration. Connecting new information to existing knowledge.

Interleaving. Mixing topics or problem types within a session.

Recognition. Identifying material when it is presented.

Desirable difficulty. Effortful study conditions that improve long-term retention.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Baseline

Honest assessment.

- Blank-page test one topic.
- Compare with your notes.
- List what you could not recall.

Week 2 - Prompts

Question bank.

- Convert three topics into questions.
- Test daily for five days.
- Retire items you know cold.

Week 3 - Spacing

Schedule.

- Apply the one-day, three-day, one-week pattern.
- Interleave two courses per session.
- Track which items keep failing.

Week 4 - Conditions

Transfer.

- Test closed-book under time.
- Explain a topic aloud from memory.
- Draw one diagram from memory.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A book on cognitive science applied to learning.
- A study skills guide covering flashcards and spacing.
- Your course outlines for topic lists to convert into questions.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is retrieval stronger than rereading?

Answer: Retrieval requires reconstructing information, which strengthens memory traces and reveals gaps; rereading only creates familiarity.

2. Give a workable spaced-review schedule.

Answer: Review one day, three days, one week, two weeks and one month after first learning.

3. What is wrong with a flashcard containing a whole paragraph?

Answer: It is too complex to retrieve quickly; one fact or concept per card works better.

4. How does sleep affect memory?

Answer: Sleep supports consolidation, stabilising and integrating newly learned information.

5. When are mnemonics useful?

Answer: For ordered lists, names or sequences; they aid recall but should be paired with understanding.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Convert one lecture into ten retrieval questions.
- [ ] Test yourself with notes closed and mark each answer.
- [ ] Build a spaced-review schedule for one week.
- [ ] Create 15 single-fact flashcards.
- [ ] Explain one topic aloud from memory for two minutes.
- [ ] Track sleep for a week and note its effect on recall.
- [ ] Re-test a topic after seven days and compare with day one.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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